scenario, the officer will never involve R&AW officers, which makes the life of bright spies very difficult. Even during visits of VVIPs from the country, the foreign officers make sure that the R&AW officers are kept at an arm's length during preparations. In recent years, we have seen that agency officers are not allowed to participate in trade delegations. This is quite worrisome,' said Rita.

Ashok Sethi, a spy earlier posted in a European country, said that the relationship between R&AW officers posted abroad with foreign office officials is on many occasions limited to 15 August and 26 January celebrations, and sometimes, a house party. Even Intelligence Bureau (IB) agents who are posted abroad as security officers often blow the covers of R&AW operatives. It's like a cold war within the set-up, he said.

'There cannot be any better example for this than the frozen relationship between ME A officers and R&AW agents in Bangladesh when Narasimha Rao was the prime minister,' said Sethi. 'Whenever we want to raise the strength of our teams in the neighbouring countries, the first opposition is always from the foreign office. They don't know anything about the functioning of the R&AW and the intelligence we pick up abroad for the security of the country, but they are authorised to write reports about our operatives and their functions. The biggest damage to a R&AW agent abroad came from one of its own agency chiefs, who exposed all the cover posts with the justification that "everyone knows you are R&AW, so why do you need the cover?" Sometimes foreign service officers are more than willing to show that the agency is dysfunctional without realising they are causing irreparable damage to not only ongoing operations but also to the lives of the agents and paid informers.'